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The yodeler who sued Yahoo!

How Gustafson took on the tech giant and won, for using his yodel as the sound of the company. <https://digit.in/jan20-38>

AUDIO LOGOS

Audio logos, sound trademarks or sonic branding are used to identify a company, product or franchise, and are designed to be easily recognisable. These auditory symbolic representations may be heard when devices are booted up, at the beginning of a movie, or at the end of advertisements. In India, these are called sound marks, and can be registered in a process similar to trademarks.

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NOKIA TUNE

The Nokia tune is called the Grande Valse, and was actually composed by Francisco Tarrega in 1902, ninety years before it was first used in a mobile phone. In 1994, the tune was used in the Nokia 2110, and went on to become one of the most recognisable ringtones in history. In 2009, it was estimated that the tune was heard 20,000 times every second, around the world.



MGM LOGO

This is the oldest entry in the list, and one that is the least crafted. Over the years, MGM has used a number of real lions as their logo, to set the tone for the epic film to follow. Each of these times, the natural roar of the lions was used as the audio logo. While five different lions were used between 1928 to 1956, since then every movie has used the roar by a lion called Leo.



THX DEEP NOTE

The THX deep note that plays at the start of every THX certified film was composed by Dr James Moorer, a sound engineer at Lucasfilm. It was first heard at the introduction of Star Wars: Episode VI – Return of the Jedi in 1983. The initial part of the score actually uses random pitches between 200 to 400 hz, moving to a sustained crescendo after 20 seconds.



YAHOO! YODEL

Not many might have heard the Yahoo! yodel, but it was actually the first sound mark to be registered in India. Wylie Gustafson accepted a one time payment of \$590 in 1996 to record the Yahoo! Yodel, for what he thought was a one off regional commercial. He belted out 20 to 30 different types of yodels in a short span of 10 minutes at a studio in LA.



20TH CENTURY FOX FANFARE

The 20th Century Fox Fanfare was originally composed in 1933 by Alfred Newman, who has won nine Oscars for music. In the 70s, the use of the audio logo had reduced, but George Lucas insisted on using it for his Star Wars movies, after which it enjoyed a resurrection. Unfortunately, Disney has now removed the fanfare from the Star Wars movies.

